

Netherlands



Astride the delta of five major rivers in northwest Europe, the Netherlands built its historic wealth on maritime trade. Rotterdam is Europe's largest port.



GEOGRAPHY

Mainly flat, with 27% of the land below sea level and protected by dunes, dikes, and canals. There are a few low hills in the south and east.



CLIMATE

Mild, rainy winters and cool summers. Gales from the North Sea are common in fall and winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Dutch have a long history of welcoming immigrants from former colonies and refugees seeking asylum. However, lack of integration is now raising fears about the failing asylum system, immigrant crime, and militant Islam. Population is mostly urban and the density is high. The state does not try to impose a particular morality on its citizens. Laws concerning sexuality, narcotics-taking, and euthanasia are among the world's most liberal.



THE ECONOMY

Major trading hub. High-profile multinationals. Diverse industrial base: chemicals, machinery, electronics, and metals. Costly social welfare system.



INSIGHT: In 2002, the Netherlands became the first country in the world to legalize euthanasia



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of the Netherlands

DATE OF FORMATION: 1648

CAPITAL: Amsterdam and The Hague

POPULATION: 16.6 million

TOTAL AREA: 16,033 sq. miles
(41,526 sq. km)

DENSITY: 1267 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Dutch*, Frisian

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 36%, other 34%, Protestant 27%, Muslim 3%

ETHNIC MIX: Dutch 82%, other 12%, Surinamese, Turkish, and Moroccan 6%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Euro = 100 cents